

April 2005 A police constable, Sunil More, raped a 17-year-old college student on Marine Drive. He was later convicted.

November 2002 A Maulana Azad Medical College student was raped by four men at knifepoint in a monument in the afternoon.

rushed to the spot and interrogated the driver. On my way home, I rang my father and we met halfway.

I took leave for a week, trying to come to terms with what could have happened. I did not want to register a police complaint, scared that it could have an adverse effect on my reputation. Our company conducted a meeting on the safety of women employees. As a result of the meeting, new safety arrangements were out in place. The latest tracking equipment was planted in every taxi, helping to identify its exact location. No woman employee was allowed to leave the office after 10 p.m. in her own vehicle. Nowa-

"Why should women be soft targets? How long can we live life by side-stepping it?"

Bangalore safe? You've got to be joking. As a journalist I have to travel at odd hours and work late as well. But harassment is not something that one faces only at night. There have been incidents in the afternoon as well. Take what happened with me on October 29, 2007. I was travelling in an autorickshaw on Convent Road and got stuck in a terrible traffic jam. I got off and decided to walk back home, because I lived just around the corner. It was only 7.30 p.m..

pavement, one of the guys called me a b****. I abused him in return. By now a crowd had gathered around us, but not a single person asked these guys why there were roughing up a girl. When I threatened an FIR, they laughed at me. That's when I really lost it. I ran behind them and hit the pillion rider. He in turn came back and kicked me.

I went home and recounted the incident to my mother. She insisted we file a complaint. It was most disappointing. The policemen could see I was hurt but they seemed least interested in filing a complaint over something they probably considered trivial. It looked like nothing would come out of it, till my newspaper office called the police station the next day. The minute the officers found out that I was in the media they swung into action and arrested the two men whose bike registration number I had noted down. They were both employed with a prestigious IT company. Once the guys found out I was a journalist, they even came to my office and apologised. But they changed their story, saying the pillion rider was having an asthma attack and that I was blocking their way. The case is yet to come up for hearing. But I hope it will be a lesson for others. Why should women always be soft targets? How long can we live life by side-stepping it?

as told to Nirmala Ravindran

AYESHA MATTHAN, 24, JOURNALIST, BANGALORE



SANJAY RAMCHANDRAN

days, one escort accompanies every three employees during the commute. Today, we hear shocking news about assaults on working women. I have worked in Bangalore for two years. When compared to other cities, Chennai is far safer for women. Yet, this happened.

as told to Mahalingam Ponnusamy

Soon enough, a few guys on motorbikes started getting onto the pavement as the roads were blocked. I saw one such bike in front of me and refused to move. But as I stood my ground, to my complete shock, one of them got off and pushed me against the wall. No one came forward to help me. When I tried to push the bike off the